



Japan — Day-by-Day Itinerary

Traveler: Luis | **Duration:** 30 days total (28 in Japan + 2 travel days) **Dates:** TBD — use the cherry blossom alignment note below to pick your start date **Currency:** All costs in USD unless noted · ¥150 = \$1 USD



Cherry Blossom Alignment Note

If **Day 0 = March 25, 2027**, the timing works out nearly perfectly: -
Tokyo D1–D8 = March 26–April 2 → **Sakura hitting peak bloom**
🌸 - Kyoto D9–D14 = April 3–8 → **Full bloom in Kyoto** 🌸 -
Kanazawa D20–D21 = April 14–15 → **Peak bloom in Kanazawa**
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Start earlier and Tokyo peak may not have arrived yet. Start later and Kyoto blossoms may have fallen.



DAY 0 — DEPARTURE: Guatemala City → Tokyo



Sleep: On the plane

Travel Plan

Leg	Route	Time	Notes
GUA → Hub	GUA → LAX, DFW, or IAH	~5h	Or GUA → MEX (Mexico City) if routing via ANA/JAL
Layover	US hub or MEX	2–4h	Clear US Customs if using US hub (need valid US visa!)
Hub → Tokyo	LAX/DFW/IAH/ MEX → NRT or HND	11–14h	Depart afternoon/evening hub-time
Total travel	Door to door	~22–26h	You cross the date line and gain a day

Before You Leave Home

- [] Check in online 24h before departure
- [] Download Japan offline maps (Google Maps) if not done
- [] Carry JR Pass exchange voucher in hand luggage
- [] Keep ¥10,000–¥20,000 in JPY cash accessible (not checked bag)
- [] Charge all devices, pack power bank

Tips

- **Sleep strategy:** try to stay awake on the first leg and sleep on the long transoceanic flight; aim to wake ~2h before landing in Tokyo so you're alert for immigration

- Wear compression socks on the long leg — Tokyo has a LOT of walking starting Day 1
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DAY 1 — TOKYO: Arrival + First Steps

 **City:** Tokyo |  **Hotel:** Tokyo Week 1 (Shinjuku, Asakusa, or Ueno area)  **Arrive:** NRT (Narita) or HND (Haneda)

At the Airport (allow 1.5–2h)

1. **Immigration:** Present passport. Japan arrival card filled on the plane. If registered on Visit Japan Web, use e-gate (faster).
2. **Customs:** Declare any cash over ¥1 million. Straightforward otherwise.
3. **Redeem JR Pass:** Head to the JR East Travel Service Center inside the arrivals hall. Exchange your voucher for the physical JR Pass.
Activate it starting today.
4. **Get Suica IC card:** At the JR ticket machines (or 7-Eleven in the terminal). Load ¥5,000–¥10,000.
5. **Pocket WiFi / SIM pickup:** If you pre-reserved, counter is in arrivals hall (IIJmio, Sakura Mobile, JAL ABC).
6. **ATM:** 7-Eleven ATMs in the airport accept foreign cards — withdraw ¥20,000–¥30,000 cash.

Airport → Hotel

Option	Route	Time	Cost
Narita Express (N'EX) 	NRT → Shinjuku/ Shibuya (direct)	~80 min	FREE with JR Pass
Limousine Bus	NRT → major Tokyo hotels	~90–120 min	¥3,200 (~\$21)
Taxi	NRT → central Tokyo	~75–90 min	¥20,000+ (~\$130) — avoid

***From HND (Haneda):** Tokyo Monorail → Hamamatsucho → JR (JR Pass covers); or Keikyū Line (Suica). HND is 30–40 min closer to the city than NRT.*

Afternoon / Evening — Gentle First Day

- **Rest at hotel:** drop bags, shower, decompress. Jet lag from Guatemala (UTC-6) to Tokyo (UTC+9) is a 15-hour difference — your body thinks it's 2am.
- **Explore your neighborhood on foot:** find the nearest konbini (convenience store). Buy onigiri, melon pan, a Pocari Sweat — your introduction to Japanese convenience store food. It's genuinely excellent.
- **Dinner nearby:** a simple bowl of ramen or tonkatsu near the hotel. Don't overthink it — this is a rest day.

- **Sleep by 9–10pm Tokyo time** to reset your internal clock. Resist the temptation to stay up.

Transport Summary

- N'EX from NRT to hotel area: **FREE with JR Pass**
 - Suica for any short metro hops: ~¥200 per ride
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DAY 2 — TOKYO: East Tokyo — Asakusa, Ueno, Akihabara

 **Stay:** Tokyo |  **Theme:** Old Tokyo + culture + markets

Morning — Asakusa (Arrive before 8am)

Senso-ji is magical before 9am. Crowds arrive hard by 10am.

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
7:00	Senso-ji Temple — oldest temple in Tokyo. Walk through Kaminarimon gate, Nakamise arcade (vendors still setting up = peaceful), main hall.	Subway to Asakusa Station (Ginza or Toei Asakusa line, Suica)	FREE
8:30	Nakamise Shopping Street — souvenirs, ningyo-yaki rice cakes, senbei crackers. Buy a few things while still quiet.	Walk	Snacks ~\$5
9:00	Asakusa neighborhood stroll — explore Hoppy Street, Kappabashi (kitchen supply district, 10 min walk), old shotengai covered market	Walk	FREE

Midday — Ueno Area

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
10:30	Ueno Park — stroll through the park; cherry blossom trees line the main path. In peak bloom this will be one of the most beautiful walks of the trip.	10-min walk or JR Yamanote to Ueno (JR Pass)	FREE
11:30	Ameyoko Market — lively outdoor market along the old train tracks. Street food, fresh seafood stalls, dried goods, cheap clothes. Buy lunch here.	Walk from Ueno Station	~\$5–8 lunch
12:30	Tokyo National Museum (optional — if you have energy) — largest collection of Japanese art and antiquities in the world	Walk from Ueno	¥1,000 (~\$7)

Afternoon — Quick Akihabara Preview

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
14:30	Akihabara — just a 2-stop JR train from Ueno. Walk Electric Town, duck into one or two stores for a preview (full day coming on Day 3)	JR Yamanote/ Keihin-Tohoku from Ueno (JR Pass)	FREE entry

Evening

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
18:00	Omoide Yokochō ("Memory Lane") — tiny alley of 20+ yakitori stalls in Shinjuku. Order chicken skewers, drink beer, squeeze in. Pure old Tokyo.	JR to Shinjuku (JR Pass), 1 min walk from west exit	~\$15–20

Transport Summary

- Suica for metro hops (~¥200–300 each)
- JR Pass for Yamanote Line (Ueno → Akihabara → Shinjuku)

DAY 3 — TOKYO: Akihabara + Nakano Broadway

 **Stay:** Tokyo |  **Theme:** Anime, manga, retro games — your day

Morning → Afternoon — Akihabara (4–5 hours)

This is your day. Budget ¥10,000–¥30,000 if shopping. Set a hard limit before you walk in.

Time	Activity	Cost
10:00	Yodobashi Akiba — 8-floor electronics/gaming/figure megastore. Just for browsing even if you don't buy.	FREE to browse
11:00	Animate Akihabara — 10 floors of manga, anime goods, doujinshi	Budget as needed
12:00	Mandarake Akihabara — vintage/used manga, figures, rare collectibles	Budget as needed
13:00	Lunch: Ramen, curry, or a set meal in the area. Don Quijote food floor for cheap bites.	~\$8–12
14:00	Retro game shops — Super Potato is the most famous; Trader, Radio Kaikan building	Budget as needed
15:00	Figure floor shops — Kotobukiya, Volks, Good Smile shops for high-end figures	Budget as needed

Getting there: JR Yamanote / Akihabara Electric Town Exit | JR Pass 

Afternoon — Nakano Broadway (2–3 hours)

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
16:00	Nakano Broadway — 4-floor mall in a quieter neighborhood. Less tourist-polished than Akihabara. Known for vintage/rare manga, Mandarake floors, used figures at better prices.	JR Chuo Line from Akihabara → Nakano (15 min, JR Pass)	FREE to browse

Evening

Time	Activity	Cost
19:00	Dinner in Akihabara or Shinjuku — curry is the natural Akihabara food. Shinjuku has 100 options within 5 min walk of the station.	~\$10–20
20:00	Optional: Maid Cafe — a uniquely Akihabara experience. Standard price is ¥500 entry + ¥700+ per drink. Set expectations correctly — it's theatrical performance, not weird. About 45 min experience.	~\$10–15

DAY 4 — TOKYO: West Tokyo — Meiji, Harajuku, Shibuya

 **Stay:** Tokyo |  **Theme:** Shrines, parks, modern Tokyo, iconic Shibuya

Morning — Harajuku / Meiji Area

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
8:30	Meiji Jingu Shrine — forested approach through towering cedar trees, very peaceful. One of the most serene places in all of Tokyo. Allow 1 hr.	JR Yamanote to Harajuku Station (JR Pass)	FREE
10:00	Yoyogi Park — adjacent to Meiji Jingu. Cherry blossom spot. Great for a picnic. Locals hang out with dogs, do music, practice sports.	Walk from shrine	FREE
11:00	Takeshita Street, Harajuku — pedestrian street of fashion, crepes, pop culture shops. Wild fashion, worth 30–45 min.	Walk	Crepe ~\$5
12:00	Lunch: Omotesando has good mid-range restaurants. Or grab from a konbini and eat in Yoyogi Park.	Walk	~\$10–15

Afternoon — Shibuya

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
13:30	Shibuya Scramble Crossing — walk through it, photograph from Starbucks above (window seat), understand why it's famous	JR to Shibuya (JR Pass), 5 min walk	FREE
14:00	Shibuya area exploration — Shibuya Center-gai, Shibuya 109, Mag's Park	Walk	FREE
15:00	Hachiko Statue — famous loyal dog statue outside Shibuya Station. Short but iconic.	Walk	FREE

Evening — Shibuya Sky ⚠️ Book Ahead

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
17:00	Shibuya Sky observation deck — open-air rooftop, 360° view, spectacular at sunset. Book a sunset time slot in advance (popular, sells out). Rooftop is open air — have a jacket.	Shibuya Scramble Square building, same station	¥2,700 (~\$18)
19:00	Dinner in Shibuya — countless options. Spanish bar Taverna (great tapas), Ichiran ramen for solo booths, Afuri ramen for yuzu flavor	Walk	~\$15–25

DAY 5 — TOKYO: Ghibli Museum + teamLab

 **Stay:** Tokyo |  **Theme:** World-class art and animation — the most special day

 *Both Ghibli Museum AND teamLab require advance tickets. Book as soon as possible.*

Morning — Ghibli Museum Pre-booked ticket required

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
09:30	Depart hotel		
10:00	Ghibli Museum, Mitaka — enter at your booked slot (10am recommended). 2–3 hours inside. A Miyazaki wonderland: original sketches, the Cat Bus room (kids only but you can see), rooftop robot soldier, exclusive short film only shown here. No photography inside the museum but absolutely worth every minute. Do not rush.	JR Chuo Line from Shinjuku → Mitaka Station (JR Pass), then Ghibli shuttle bus ¥320 RT or 15-min walk	¥1,000 (~\$7) + ¥160 bus

Midday — Kichijoji Area

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
13:00	Lunch in Kichijoji — Mitaka's neighboring town; great independent restaurants. Inokashira Park (5-min walk from Kichijoji Station) is perfect for a lakeside post-lunch walk or renting a rowboat (¥700/30 min)	Walk from museum or short bus	~\$12–18 lunch
14:30	Inokashira Park — peaceful park with a lake, another strong cherry blossom spot	Walk from Kichijoji	FREE

Evening — teamLab ⚠️ Pre-booked ticket required

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
16:30	Depart Kichijoji for teamLab		
17:30	teamLab Planets (Toyosu) OR teamLab Borderless (Azabudai Hills) — immersive digital art. Planets: more intimate, you walk barefoot through water; about 1.5 hrs. Borderless: much larger multi-floor labyrinth; 2–3 hrs. You have tickets for one. Book an evening slot — the light art is more vivid after dark.	JR Keiyo Line or Yurikamome to Shin-Toyosu (Planets) / Tokyo Metro Hibiya Line to Roppongi (Borderless)	¥4,200– ¥5,600
20:00	Dinner near teamLab venue or back in your neighborhood		~\$15– 20

DAY 6 — TOKYO → NIKKO (Day Trip)

📍 **Stay:** Tokyo | 🎯 **Theme:** UNESCO mountain shrines + waterfalls — the most dramatic day trip from Tokyo

Return to Tokyo hotel same night.

Travel to Nikko

Time	Activity	Route	Cost
6:45	Depart hotel for Asakusa Station	Subway to Asakusa	~¥200
7:20	Tobu Asakusa Station → Tobu-Nikko Station	Tobu Nikko Line limited express "Revaty Kagon" (fastest, 1h50m)	¥2,800 OW (~\$19) ⚠️ NOT covered by JR Pass — buy at Asakusa Tobu station
9:10	Arrive Tobu-Nikko Station		
9:15	Walk or take bus to shrine complex (~10 min)	Local bus ¥250 or 25-min walk up the hill	

At Nikko (shrine complex, ~5 hours)

Time	Activity	Cost
9:30	Shinkyo Sacred Bridge — bright vermilion bridge over the gorge. Photo stop.	¥500 to cross (~\$3)
10:00	Rinnoji Temple — three giant gold Buddhas, Shoyo-en strolling garden	¥1,000 (~\$7)
10:45	Tosho-gu Shrine — the main event. Most elaborately decorated shrine in Japan. Tokugawa Ieyasu's mausoleum. Carved gate (Yomeimon) is mind-bending. Budget 1.5–2 hrs.	¥1,600 (~\$11)
12:30	Lunch near Shinkyo Bridge — try yuba (tofu skin) dishes, a Nikko specialty. Multiple restaurants in the area.	~\$12–18

Afternoon — Up to the Lake

Time	Activity	Route	Cost
13:30	Bus up to Lake Chuzenji	Bus from Nikko Bus Terminal (¥1,150, ~45 min up Irohazaka winding road — 48 hairpin turns!)	¥1,150 (~\$8)
14:30	Kegon Waterfall — Japan's most famous waterfall, 97m drop. Take the elevator to the base for the best view. 30 min here.	Walk from bus stop	Elevator ¥570 (~\$4)
15:00	Lake Chuzenji — walk the lakeside. Serene mountain lake. Great photo backdrop. 30–45 min.	Walk	FREE
15:45	Bus back to Nikko town	Return bus	¥1,150
16:00	Taiyuin Mausoleum — Tokugawa Iemitsu's tomb. Quieter than Toshogu, equally detailed. Worth 45 min.	Walk	¥550 (~\$4)

Return to Tokyo

Time	Activity	Route	Cost
17:15	Depart Tobu-Nikko Station	Tobu Nikko Line → Asakusa (~2h)	¥2,800
19:15	Arrive Asakusa, Tokyo		
19:30	Dinner: Kaminarimon area has great dinner options — tempura, soba, sukiyaki	Walk from Asakusa	~\$15–25

Day Total transport: ~¥8,000+ (~\$53) — this is one of the more expensive days for transport

 DAY 7 — TOKYO: Kodokan + Skytree + Odaiba

 **Stay:** Tokyo |  **Theme:** Martial arts, modern Tokyo, harbor views

Morning — Kodokan Judo Institute

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
9:00	Kodokan Judo Institute — world headquarters of Judo founded by Jigoro Kano. Morning practice sessions (randori) typically happen 9:30–11:30am. Museum on the ground floor covers the history of Judo. Check the official practice schedule in advance at kdkjd.org .	Tokyo Metro Marunouchi or Namboku Line to Korakuen Station (Suica)	FREE (museum + viewing)
11:00	Koishikawa Korakuen Garden — one of the oldest gardens in Tokyo, 2-min walk from Kodokan. Quiet, beautiful, underrated.	Walk	¥300 (~\$2)

Midday — Asakusa / Skytree Area

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
12:00	Lunch: Ramen in the Akihabara or Ueno area on your way to Asakusa	JR trains (JR Pass)	~\$8–12
13:30	Tokyo Skytree — tallest structure in Japan (634m). Tembo Deck at 350m for stunning views. On a clear day you can see Mt. Fuji. Consider booking ahead — shorter queues.	Tobu Skytree Line from Asakusa (2 min) or walk (15 min)	¥2,100 deck (~\$14), ¥3,000 with Galleria (~\$20)

Afternoon — Odaiba

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
15:30	Odaiba Waterfront — artificial island with views back to Rainbow Bridge and Tokyo skyline. Walk the waterfront.	Yurikamome Line from Shimbashi (Suica, ~¥400)	FREE to walk
16:00	teamLab Borderless (if you chose Planets on Day 5 instead)	Odaiba area → Azabudai Hills	¥3,800–5,600
16:00	Gundam Base Tokyo — massive Gunpla store + life-size Gundam display	DiverCity Tokyo, walk from Odaiba-Kaihin-Koen station	FREE to enter
17:00	Jump Shop — official Shonen Jump merch store	Same mall	FREE to enter

Evening

Time	Activity	Cost
19:00	Omoide Yokochō (Memory Lane), Shinjuku — if you missed it on Day 2. Or explore Shinjuku's Golden Gai — 200+ tiny bars in a 6-alley cluster. Order whatever the bartender recommends. Most have a ¥500 cover charge.	~\$15–25

DAY 8 — TOKYO: Yanaka + Shimokitazawa + Flexible

 **Stay:** Tokyo |  **Theme:** Old-town Tokyo, vintage culture, breathing room

Morning — Yanaka (Old Shitamachi Tokyo)

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
9:00	Yanaka Cemetery — sounds odd but it's beautiful, especially in cherry blossom season. A peaceful walk through old Japan.	JR Yamanote to Nippori Station (JR Pass)	FREE
9:45	Yanaka Ginza — a preserved old-fashioned covered shopping street. Tofu shops, sembei vendors, cat cafes. Feels like Tokyo from 50 years ago.	5-min walk from Nippori	Browse free; snacks ~\$5
11:00	Nezu Shrine — mini Fushimi Inari-style torii tunnel, much less crowded. Hidden gem.	15-min walk or short bus	FREE

Afternoon — Shimokitazawa (Vintage + Indie Culture)

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
12:30	Lunch in Shimokitazawa — excellent coffee shops and small restaurants	Keio Inokashira Line from Shibuya or Odakyu from Shinjuku (Suica)	~\$12–15
13:30	Shimokitazawa vintage shops — Japan's best vintage clothing neighborhood. Hundreds of independent shops. Budget as needed.	Walk	Budget ¥5,000– 15,000 if shopping
15:30	Koenji (optional) — similar vintage vibe, one stop east on Chuo-Sobu Line (JR Pass). More hardcore secondhand.	10-min JR train	

Evening — Flexible Last Night in Week 1 Tokyo

- **Option A:** Roppongi Hills — Mori Art Museum (contemporary art, ¥2,000), incredible night view from 52F, upscale dinner
- **Option B:** Ginza — window shop Japan's most expensive street, Kabuki-za single-act show
- **Option C:** Shinjuku — explore whatever you haven't seen yet; Ni-chome neighborhood; department store basement food hall (depachika) at Isetan

- **Option D:** Rest — 8 days of Tokyo with jet lag is tiring. Sleep early, pack your bag for Kyoto tomorrow.

DAY 9 — TRAVEL TO KYOTO + FUSHIMI INARI

 **Move:** Tokyo → Kyoto |  **Hotel:** Kyoto (6 nights)

Morning — Shinkansen to Kyoto

Time	Activity	Route	Cost
8:00	Check out of Tokyo hotel, store luggage at station		
8:30	Tokyo Station → Kyoto Station	JR Hikari or Sakura Shinkansen from Tokyo Station (platform 14–19). Reserve seats free at JR office. Do NOT take Nozomi — not covered by JR Pass.	FREE with JR Pass
10:45	Arrive Kyoto Station	Journey: ~2h15m	
11:00	Check in or store luggage at Kyoto hotel	Walk or taxi from station	

💡 **Kyoto Station** is enormous — budget 10 minutes to navigate it. The Shinkansen platform is on the ground floor; most hotels are north (Kawaramachi direction) or south (Toji direction) of the station.

Afternoon — Fushimi Inari Taisha

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
14:00	Fushimi Inari Taisha — thousands of vermilion torii gates winding up Mt. Inari. The lower gates (30 min walk) are the iconic photos. The full mountain hike to the summit and back is 4 hours. Go at least to the mid-station (Yotsutsuji intersection, ~45 min up) for the best views. Afternoon on a weekday is manageable; avoid weekend midday.	JR Nara Line from Kyoto Station → Inari Station (5 min, JR Pass ✅). Walk straight out of the station — shrine is 1 min away.	FREE
16:30	Evening atmosphere along the lower torii is atmospheric as crowds thin	Walk down	FREE

Evening

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
18:00	Nishiki Market area — "Kyoto's Kitchen" — 100+ food stalls in a covered arcade. Great for snacks and dinner. Try tamago dango, yuba, pickles.	Subway or bus to Shijo area	Snacks/dinner ~\$15

DAY 10 — KYOTO: Higashiyama Temples

 **Stay:** Kyoto |  **Theme:** Eastern mountain temples, Japan's most iconic streetscape

Morning — Kiyomizu-dera (Go Early)

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
7:30	Kiyomizu-dera — Kyoto's most famous temple, wooden stage jutting out over the hillside with sweeping city views. Go at 7:30–8:00am before crowds. The walk up through Sannen-zaka and Ninen-zaka stone streets is beautiful even before the temple.	Bus 100 or 206 from Kyoto Station to Kiyomizu-michi, then 10-min uphill walk	¥500 (~\$3)
9:00	Sannen-zaka & Ninen-zaka — preserved stone-paved lanes with Meiji-era shops. Buy matcha soft serve. Best 30 min of the trip for photos.	Walk from Kiyomizu	FREE

Midday

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
10:00	Sanjusangen-do — a 120m long hall with 1,001 golden life-size Kannon statues in perfect formation. Quietly overwhelming. 45–60 min.	15-min walk south from Kiyomizu-dera area	¥600 (~\$4)
11:30	Lunch: Higashiyama area has many teahouses and kaiseki-style lunch sets. Okutan (near Nanzen-ji) serves tofu kaiseki lunch ~¥3,500 (\$23).	Walk	~\$20–35

Afternoon — Northern Higashiyama

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
13:00	Ginkaku-ji (Silver Pavilion) — understated wabi-sabi beauty; the sand garden (kogetsudai) raked into a perfect cone is hypnotic. 45–60 min.	Bus 100 from Gion to Ginkakuji-michi	¥500 (~\$3)
14:00	Philosopher's Path — 2km canal walk lined with cherry trees (stunning in bloom). Connects Ginkaku-ji south toward Nanzen-ji. Walk slowly. 45 min.	Walk	FREE
15:00	Nanzen-ji Temple — huge Zen temple with a towering sanmon gate and aqueduct you can walk under. FREE to enter grounds; sub-temple interiors ¥500–600.	Walk from Philosopher's Path	Grounds FREE

Evening — Gion

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
17:30	Gion District — walk Hanamachi-dori (the cobbled lane running south from Shijo), then Ishibei-koji alley. Best 30 min starting at dusk for the chance to spot a maiko/geiko hurrying to an appointment. Don't block them or ask for photos — just observe respectfully.	Bus or walk from Nanzen-ji area	FREE
19:00	Dinner: Pontocho Alley — narrow lantern-lit lane of restaurants running parallel to the Kamogawa river. Outdoor terrace dining (kawayuka) available in warm months. Price range varies widely from cheap ramen at ¥900 to mid-range Kyoto cuisine at ¥4,000–6,000.	Walk from Gion	~\$15–40

DAY 11 — KYOTO: Northern Kyoto — Golden Pavilion, Zen Gardens, Castle

 **Stay:** Kyoto |  **Theme:** The most famous sights in Kyoto, done at an unhurried pace

Morning — Kinkaku-ji + Ryoan-ji (Go Early)

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
8:00	Kinkaku-ji (Golden Pavilion) — arrives by 8am before tour buses. The gold-leafed temple reflected in the mirror pond. 30–45 min is enough — it's a one-view wonder, beautiful but small.	Bus 101 or 205 from central Kyoto to Kinkakuji-michi	¥500 (~\$3)
9:00	Ryoan-ji — Japan's most famous Zen rock garden. 15 stones arranged so that no matter where you stand, one is hidden. 45 min contemplation. Best when not crowded.	10-min walk from Kinkaku-ji	¥600 (~\$4)
10:30	Daitoku-ji Complex — 22 sub-temples spread across a quiet complex. Some open only rarely. Koto-in and Daisen-in are usually open (¥400–700 each). A deeply calm experience, almost no tourists.	Bus from Ryoan-ji area	¥400–700 per sub-temple

Midday

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
12:30	Lunch: Imamiya Shrine area has two famous aburi mochi restaurants (Kazariya and Ichiwa) — chewy grilled rice cakes with white miso sauce. Famous for 1,000+ years. Very cheap (~¥500).	Walk from Daitoku-ji	¥500 (~\$3)

Afternoon — Nijo Castle

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
14:00	Nijo-jo Castle — the Tokugawa shogun's Kyoto palace. Two concentric moats, incredible painted sliding doors inside the Ninomaru Palace, and famous "nightingale floors" that squeak to detect intruders. UNESCO World Heritage. Allow 1.5–2 hrs.	Bus or subway to Nijo-jo-mae	¥1,300 (~\$9)
16:30	Pontocho or Nishiki Market — wrap up the afternoon with a snack stroll	Bus or walk	

Evening

Time	Activity	Cost
18:30	Dinner: Kyoto-style kaiseki is the thing to try at least once. A casual kaiseki lunch set runs ¥2,500–4,000; dinner kaiseki can be ¥8,000–15,000. Tonight is a good night for mid-range (¥3,000–5,000) — try a restaurant on or near Pontocho.	~\$20–35

DAY 12 — KYOTO: Arashiyama + Gion Evening

 **Stay:** Kyoto |  **Theme:** Bamboo at dawn, mountain temples, romantic Gion evening

Early Morning — Arashiyama Bamboo Grove (Arrive 6:30am)

The bamboo grove at midday is a crowded disappointment. At dawn it's one of the most ethereal places on Earth. Set your alarm.

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
6:00	Depart hotel		
6:30	Arashiyama Bamboo Grove — at this hour it's just you, the bamboo, and the sound of wind. The entire character of the place changes. 30–45 min walk through.	JR Sagano Line from Kyoto Station → Saga-Arashiyama (15 min, JR Pass )	FREE
7:30	Tenryu-ji temple gardens — opens 8:00am. Zen garden with borrowed scenery of the Arashiyama mountains. One of the finest gardens in Japan.	Walk from bamboo grove	¥500 garden (~\$3)
8:30	Breakfast: Arashiyama riverside cafes start opening around 8–9am. Or grab onigiri from a convenience store before you leave.		~\$5–10

Morning — Sagano Romantic Train

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
9:30	Sagano Scenic Railway (Torokko Train) — 7km open-air train through the Hozugawa River gorge, autumn foliage and mountain scenery. Book in advance if possible; tickets sell out. Torokko Saga → Torokko Kameoka (25 min one way).	Station adjacent to Saga-Arashiyama	¥880 OW (~\$6) ⚠️ NOT JR Pass

Midday

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
11:00	Jojakko-ji & Nisonin — quieter hillside temples above Arashiyama, with great maple tree views; few tourists. 45 min each.	10-min walk uphill from bamboo grove	¥500 each
13:00	Lunch in Arashiyama — riverside tofu restaurant or Arashiyama Yoshimura (soba with mountain view).	Walk	~\$15–20
14:00	Monkey Park Iwatayama (optional) — hike 15 min up a hill, find 120 Japanese macaques. Views of Kyoto below.	Walk from Arashiyama station	¥600 (~\$4)

Evening — Gion (Second, Deeper Visit)

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
17:00	Travel back to Kyoto central area	JR from Saga-Arashiyama → Kyoto Station (JR Pass)	FREE
17:30	Gion's backstreets — explore Shirakawa canal (lined with weeping cherry and traditional machiya), Ishibei-koji alley	Walk from Shijo area	FREE
19:00	Pontocho dinner — book a spot with kawayuka terrace seating if warm enough; dining over the Kamo River is quintessential Kyoto	Walk	~\$25–50

DAY 13 — KYOTO → NARA (Day Trip)

 **Stay:** Kyoto |  **Theme:** Ancient capital, giant Buddha, sacred deer

Travel to Nara

Time	Activity	Route	Cost
7:45	Depart Kyoto hotel		
8:00	Kyoto Station → Nara Station	JR Nara Line (Miyakoji Rapid) — 45 min	FREE with JR Pass 
8:50	Arrive Nara. Walk east toward the park (~15 min)		

At Nara

Time	Activity	Cost
9:00	Nara Park — 1,200 free-roaming sacred deer will approach you immediately. Buy deer crackers (shika senbei) at park stalls (¥200). Warning: they are charming AND aggressive. Protect your map, food, and bag.	¥200 deer crackers (~\$1)
10:30	Todayi-ji Temple — the Great Buddha (Daibutsu). At 15m tall, it's genuinely massive. The temple hall itself is the world's largest wooden structure. 1–1.5 hrs.	¥800 (~\$5)
12:00	Lunch: Nishiki-koji or Higashimuki shopping arcade area near the station. Kakinoha-zushi (persimmon leaf-wrapped sushi) is the Nara specialty.	~\$10–15
13:00	Kasuga Taisha Shrine — 3,000 stone and bronze lanterns line the approaches. Deep in a cedar forest, very atmospheric.	FREE (inner sanctuary ¥500)
14:00	Kofuku-ji Temple — five-story pagoda reflected in Sarusawa Pond. Museum has incredible 8th-century statues.	FREE grounds, museum ¥700
15:00	Isuien Garden (optional) — two-part classical garden with Mt. Wakakusa borrowed scenery. Peaceful and beautiful.	¥900 (~\$6)
16:00	Head back toward Nara Station	Walk ~15 min

Return to Kyoto

Time	Route	Cost
16:15	JR Nara Line → Kyoto (~45 min, JR Pass )	FREE
17:00	Arrive Kyoto. Dinner in Gion or Pontocho area	~\$15–25

DAY 14 — KYOTO: Hidden Kyoto — Kurama & Kibune Mountains

 **Stay:** Kyoto |  **Theme:** Mountain villages, cedar forest hike, riverside dining

Morning — Kurama & Kibune

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
8:30	Eizan Railway from Demachiyanagi Station → Kurama Station	Eizan Kurama Line (18 min) ⚠ NOT JR Pass	¥430 (~\$3)
9:00	Kurama-dera Temple — take the cable car partway up (¥200) or hike 30 min. Ancient temple complex on the mountain.	Cable car ¥200 or hike	Temple entry ¥500
10:00	Hike Kurama → Kibune — 2.5km mountain trail through old-growth cedar forest connecting the two villages. 1–1.5 hours of moderate hiking. One of the best hikes in the Kyoto region.	Trail from Kurama temple	FREE
11:30	Arrive Kibune village — small cluster of restaurants along a stream in a narrow mountain valley. If visiting in warmer months, restaurants place tables on platforms over the stream (kawayuka dining).	Arrive on foot	
12:00	Lunch in Kibune — streamside kaiseki or noodles. Lunch sets start around ¥2,500–4,000. Worth splurging here — it's a unique setting.	¥2,500–4,000 (~\$17–27)	
13:30			¥430

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
	Eizan Railway back toward Kyoto	Kibune → Kibuneguchi Station → back to Demachiyanagi	

Afternoon — Final Kyoto Hours

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
14:30	Nishijin Textile Center — watch Nishijin-ori obi weaving on Jacquard looms. Free to enter, fascinating craft.	Bus from central Kyoto	FREE
15:30	Nijo-jo Castle night view (if it's the illumination season) or Fushimi Inari at dusk again — your last chance	Bus	¥500–1,300

Evening — Farewell Kyoto Dinner

- **Tea ceremony** (if not done yet) — book at Urasenke school or a tourist-friendly school near Gion: ¥3,000–8,000 (\$20–53). A proper send-off for Kyoto.
 - **Or:** A long final dinner on Pontocho. Sit outside if the weather allows. Order sake.
-

DAY 15 — TRAVEL TO OSAKA + DOTONBORI

 **Move:** Kyoto → Osaka |  **Hotel:** Osaka (3 nights, Namba or Shinsaibashi area)

Morning — Travel (15–30 min)

Time	Activity	Route	Cost
10:00	Check out of Kyoto hotel		
10:30	Kyoto Station → Osaka (JR Osaka Station)	JR Special Rapid or Shinkansen (1 stop), 14–28 min	FREE with JR Pass 
11:00	Check in / store luggage at Osaka hotel		

Osaka is only 14–28 minutes from Kyoto. If you have early morning Kyoto things left, easily done before checkout.

Afternoon

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
13:00	Kuromon Ichiba Market — "Osaka's kitchen." 170+ stalls of fresh seafood, wagyu, street snacks. Eat lunch by grazing stall to stall: tuna, crab, octopus balls, oysters. Budget ¥1,500–2,500 for a grazing lunch.	Subway to Nippombashi or Namba area (Suica)	~\$10–17
14:30	Dotonbori — the neon canal district. Walk the canal; photograph the Glico Running Man; queue for famous takoyaki at Kukurū. Overwhelming and fun.	Walk from Kuromon	FREE
15:30	Shinsaibashi Shopping Arcade — Japan's longest covered shopping street; good for souvenirs and fashion	Walk	FREE to browse

Evening — Osaka Street Food Crawl

Osaka's calling card is food. Tonight is pure eating.

Food	Where	Cost
Takoyaki (octopus balls)	Dotonbori or Kukururu near Namba	¥600–800
Okonomiyaki (savory pancake)	Mizuno near Dotonbori — the most famous spot	¥1,200–1,800
Kushikatsu (deep-fried skewers)	Daruma in Shinsekai or any Dotonbori spot	¥150–250/skewer
Takoyaki round 2	It's Osaka. You're allowed.	

DAY 16 — OSAKA: Universal Studios Japan (Full Day)

 **Stay:** Osaka |  **Theme:** Nintendo World — the whole reason to come to Osaka

 *Book your day ticket AND Nintendo World Express Pass in advance — both sell out weeks ahead.*

Travel to USJ

Time	Activity	Route	Cost
8:00	Depart hotel		
8:30	JR Osaka Station → Universal City Station	JR Yumesaki Line (Osaka Loop Line connection, 5 min)	FREE with JR Pass 
8:45	Arrive USJ — gates typically open at 9am, sometimes 8am on peak days		

At USJ — Strategy

Priority	Area	What to Do
First 90 min	Super Nintendo World	Go immediately at opening. Use Express Pass for Mario Kart. Get the Power-Up Band wristband (¥4,500) to collect coins and stamps.
Next 2 hrs	Donkey Kong Country (new expansion)	New in 2024; lines are long. Hit this second while Nintendo lines reset.
After lunch	Harry Potter — Hogsmeade	Butterbeer, Forbidden Journey ride. Use Express Pass.
Afternoon	Hollywood, New York, Jurassic World	Ride Jurassic World, The Amazing Adventures of Spider-Man, Hollywood Dream.
Evening	Final Nintendo loop	Lines drop after 4pm — do Mario Kart again if you want

Day Ticket: ¥8,600–¥11,800 (\$57–79) depending on date

Express Pass (recommended): ¥4,000–¥8,000 extra (\$27–53) — worth it for Nintendo World

Dinner

- **Inside USJ:** Multiple themed restaurants but expensive (~¥1,500–2,500)

- **Near Universal City:** Several casual restaurants just outside the park gates



DAY 17 — OSAKA: Castle + Aquarium + Umeda



Stay: Osaka |  **Theme:** History, ocean life, city views

Morning — Osaka Castle

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
9:00	Osaka Castle — iconic 16th-century castle reconstructed in 1931; beautifully restored. The surrounding moat and cherry trees are stunning in bloom. Museum inside traces Toyotomi Hideyoshi's history. Castle Park grounds are free; inner castle is ¥1,200.	Subway to Tanimachi 4-chome or Osakajo-koen (Suica)	¥1,200 (~\$8)
10:30	Castle park stroll — the outer grounds are enormous and free. Cherry blossoms here are excellent if timing is right.	Walk	FREE

Midday — Shinsekai

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
12:00	Shinsekai — retro 1920s-style entertainment district. Under the Tsutenkaku tower. Home of kushikatsu (the original). Gritty, authentic, not touristy. Great for lunch.	Subway to Dobutsuen-mae (Suica)	FREE to walk
12:30	Lunch: Kushikatsu Daruma — the original kushikatsu chain from Shinsekai. Order the set, dip once in the communal sauce (never twice!), enjoy.	Walk	~\$12–18

Afternoon — Osaka Aquarium

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
14:00	Osaka Aquarium Kaiyukan — consistently ranked one of the best aquariums in the world. The central tank is 9m deep and contains whale sharks. Genuinely jaw-dropping. 2–3 hours.	Subway Chuo Line to Osakako (Suica)	¥2,700 (~\$18)

Evening — Umeda Sky Building

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
17:30	Umeda Sky Building — Floating Garden Observatory — two towers connected by a mid-air ring at 170m. Open-air deck. Spectacular at night. Worth the trip.	Subway to Umeda or JR Osaka Station (JR Pass)	¥1,500 (~\$10)
19:00	Final Osaka dinner — the Umeda area has excellent food. Or head back to Dotonbori for one last street food round.	Walk	~\$15–25

DAY 18 — TRAVEL TO HIROSHIMA + PEACE MEMORIAL

 **Move:** Osaka → Hiroshima |  **Hotel:** Hiroshima (2 nights, near Peace Park or station)

Today's schedule is intentionally light after arrival. The Peace Museum needs unhurried, attentive time.

Morning – Shinkansen to Hiroshima

Time	Activity	Route	Cost
9:00	Check out Osaka		
9:30	Shin-Osaka Station → Hiroshima Station	JR Hikari or Sakura Shinkansen (50 min)	FREE with JR Pass 
10:20	Arrive Hiroshima. Check in / store luggage.	Walk or taxi from station	

Afternoon — Peace Memorial (Allow 3–4 hours, don't rush)

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
11:30	Peace Memorial Park — walk the grounds. Cenotaph, Flame of Peace (burns until all nuclear weapons are gone), Children's Peace Monument (1,000 origami cranes). Quiet and moving.	Tram (Hiroden) from Hiroshima Station → Genbaku-dome-mae (Suica, ¥180)	FREE
12:00	Atomic Bomb Dome (Genbaku Dome) — the only building left standing near the hypocenter; preserved as-it-was immediately after the blast. UNESCO World Heritage. Stand here for 10 minutes.	Walk from Peace Park	FREE
12:30	Lunch near Peace Park — Hiroshima-style okonomiyaki is one of the great regional dishes in Japan (layered with noodles, unlike Osaka style). Okonomimura building has 25 okonomiyaki restaurants on 3 floors. Try any.	Walk	~\$10–15
14:00	Hiroshima Peace Memorial Museum — the most powerful museum in Japan and one of the most powerful in the world. Detailed exhibits on August 6, 1945: shadows burned into walls, personal items, a watch stopped at 8:15am. Allow 1.5–2 hours. Do not rush this.	Walk from park	¥200 (~\$1)

Evening

Time	Activity	Cost
17:00	Hiroshima Castle (optional, if energy remains) — reconstructed castle; regional history inside. 1 hr.	¥370 (~\$2)
19:00	Dinner: Hiroshima okonomiyaki — if you haven't yet, tonight's the night. Also try Hiroshima tsukemen (cold dipping ramen).	~\$12– 20

DAY 19 — MIYAJIMA ISLAND

 **Stay:** Hiroshima |  **Theme:** Floating torii gate — one of Japan's top 3 views

Check the tide times before you go. The "floating" torii is only floating at high tide. At low tide you can walk out to it.

Travel to Miyajima

Time	Activity	Route	Cost
8:00	Depart hotel		
8:15	Hiroshima Station → Miyajimaguchi	JR San'yo Line from Hiroshima Station (25 min)	FREE with JR Pass 
8:45	Miyajimaguchi → Miyajima Island	JR Ferry (10 min)	FREE with JR Pass 
9:00	Arrive Miyajima		

On Miyajima Island (Full Day)

Time	Activity	Cost
9:00	Deer and waterfront walk — sacred deer roam freely, same as Nara. More photogenic against the torii gate backdrop.	FREE
9:30	Itsukushima Shrine — the floating torii gate. The bright vermilion gate in the sea is iconic Japan. At high tide, walk out on the covered pier through the shrine.	¥300 (~\$2)
10:30	Daisho-in Temple — 500 stone lanterns, unusual statues, prayer wheels, beautiful hillside complex. Less visited than the shrine but arguably more interesting. 1 hr.	FREE
12:00	Oyster lunch — Miyajima is famous for oysters; roasted, fried, or on rice. Many stalls along the shopping street.	~\$12–18
13:00	Momijidani Park — maple leaf valley; lovely walk toward the Mt. Misen ropeway	FREE
13:30	Hike or Ropeway up Mt. Misen (optional but recommended) — highest point on the island at 535m. Views of the Seto Inland Sea are extraordinary. Ropeway up + hike to summit (~30 min extra from ropeway top). OR full hike up (~90 min, rewarding).	Ropeway ¥2,000 RT (~\$13)
15:30	Wander the shopping street — try maple leaf manju (sweet pastry in leaf shape, a Miyajima specialty)	~\$3–5

Return to Hiroshima + Pack for Kanazawa

Time	Route	Cost
16:30	JR Ferry → Miyajimaguchi → JR back to Hiroshima Station (JR Pass )	FREE
17:30	Back in Hiroshima. Light dinner. Pack bags tonight — traveling to Kanazawa tomorrow.	~\$10– 15

DAY 20 — TRAVEL TO KANAZAWA + KENROKU- EN

 **Move:** Hiroshima → Kanazawa |  **Hotel:** Kanazawa (2 nights)

Morning — Shinkansen Connection

Time	Activity	Route	Cost
8:30	Check out Hiroshima		
9:00	Hiroshima → Shin-Osaka	JR Hikari Shinkansen (50 min)	FREE with JR Pass 
10:00	Transfer at Shin-Osaka	Walk to Thunderbird platform	
10:30	Shin-Osaka → Kanazawa	JR Thunderbird Limited Express (2h25m)	FREE with JR Pass 
13:00	Arrive Kanazawa. Check in.	Taxi or bus from station (~¥700)	

Total travel time: ~4.5 hours. Sit on the left side of the Thunderbird facing forward — you'll see the Noto Peninsula coastline briefly.

Afternoon — Kenroku-en Garden

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
14:00	Kenroku-en Garden — consistently ranked one of Japan's top 3 gardens. Enormous strolling garden with ponds, stone lanterns, and Kotoji toro (two-legged stone lantern, the symbol of Kanazawa). In cherry blossom season: extraordinary. Budget 1.5–2 hours minimum.	Bus 100 from Kanazawa Station to Kenrokuen-shita	¥320 (~\$2)
16:00	Kanazawa Castle Park — adjacent to Kenroku-en, free to walk the grounds. Some buildings ¥320.	Walk	Grounds FREE

Evening — Omicho Market

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
17:30	Omicho Market — Kanazawa's legendary covered seafood market. Famous for crab (kani — Kanazawa is one of the best places in Japan for crab) and uni (sea urchin). Dinner time in the market restaurants.	10-min walk from station or bus	~\$20–35 for dinner

DAY 21 — KANAZAWA: Art, Geisha Districts, Samurai

 **Stay:** Kanazawa |  **Theme:** Hidden gem city — geisha, samurai, contemporary art

Morning — 21st Century Museum

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
9:30	21st Century Museum of Contemporary Art — the round building is itself a work of art. The free zone has great installations. The paid exhibitions (¥1,020) are usually world-class. The "Swimming Pool" installation by Leandro Erlich (you stand at the bottom of a "pool" while people walk above on the glass surface) is the most photographed. Check what's showing.	Bus or walk from hotel	FREE zone + ¥1,020 paid exhibitions (~\$7)

Midday — Higashi Chaya

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
11:00	Higashi Chaya District — Kanazawa's best-preserved historic geisha district. Traditional machiya (townhouses). Some teahouses open for visits (¥500+). Morning is quiet and atmospheric.	15-min walk from museum or bus	FREE to walk; teahouse ¥500
12:30	Lunch: Higashi Chaya area has good Japanese restaurants. Or head to Omicho for fresh seafood.	Walk	~\$12-20

Afternoon — Nagamachi + Nishi Chaya

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
14:00	Nagamachi Samurai District — preserved samurai residences with mud-walled lanes and earthen walls. Nomura-ke samurai house open for visits (¥500). Very atmospheric.	Walk from museum area	FREE to walk; Nomura-ke ¥550
15:30	Nishi Chaya District (optional) — quieter western geisha district; less visited	15-min walk	FREE

Evening — Last Kanazawa

Time	Activity	Cost
18:00	Gold leaf workshop (optional) — Kanazawa produces 99% of Japan's gold leaf. Some workshops offer experience making gold leaf sweets or accessories. Book in advance (~¥2,000).	
19:00	Final dinner: Kanazawa's specialty is Kaga cuisine (local kaiseki). Or go back to Omicho for crab.	~\$20–40

***Tonight:** Pack bag. Fly to Okinawa tomorrow — completely different world.*



DAY 22 — FLY TO OKINAWA + NAHA CITY

 **Move:** Kanazawa → Naha, Okinawa |  **Hotel:** Naha (4 nights, Kokusai-dori area)

Morning – Travel to Airport

Time	Activity	Route	Cost
7:30	Depart hotel		
8:00	Kanazawa → Komatsu Airport (KMQ)	Taxi or Hokutetsu bus from Kanazawa Station (~45 min)	¥800– 1,200 bus
10:00	Fly Komatsu (KMQ) → Naha (OKA)	ANA, JAL, or Peach (book separately – NOT JR Pass)	~\$60–120

Alternative if no direct KMQ→OKA flight: Train Kanazawa → Osaka (~2.5h, JR Pass), then fly Osaka Itami (ITM) or Kansai (KIX) → Naha (~1.5h). Total ~5–6h travel but more flight options.

Time	Activity	Route	Cost
12:00	Arrive Naha Airport		
12:30	Airport → Hotel	Yui Rail (monorail) from airport to Miehashi or Kencho-mae Station	¥260 (~\$2)
13:00	Check in hotel		

Welcome to Okinawa. The air is warmer, the pace is slower, the food is completely different, the people are the most relaxed in Japan. Take a breath.

Afternoon — Naha Orientation

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
14:00	Shuri Castle — UNESCO-listed palace of the Ryukyu Kingdom, recently restored after a 2019 fire. Vivid red architecture unlike anything on the mainland. 1.5–2 hrs.	Bus or taxi from hotel (~15 min)	¥400 (~\$3)
16:00	Seifa-utaki (optional) — holiest sacred site of the Ryukyu religion; limestone cave and sea view. 1 hr.	Taxi or tour	¥300 (~\$2)

Evening — Kokusai-dori

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
17:30	Kokusai-dori (International Street) — 1.6km of restaurants, souvenir shops, Okinawan craft stores. The main tourist drag but genuinely fun.	Walk from hotel if staying nearby	FREE
18:30	Makishi Public Market — upstairs restaurants will cook the fresh fish you pick downstairs. A great Okinawa experience.	Walk from Kokusai-dori	~\$15–25
20:00	Okinawan food to try tonight: Goya champuru (bitter melon stir-fry with tofu and pork), soki soba (Okinawan noodles with pork rib), awamori (Okinawan rice spirit — local substitute for sake)	Various restaurants	

DAY 23 — CENTRAL OKINAWA (Rental Car Day)

 **Stay:** Naha |  **Theme:** Dramatic coastal scenery, castle ruins, American presence

 *Public transport outside Naha is extremely limited. Rent a car for this day. International Driving License required. **Book car in advance** — Okinawa car rentals fill up fast.*

Morning

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
8:30	Pick up rental car	Car rental near Naha airport or station (~¥4,000–6,000/day)	
9:30	Nakagusuku Castle Ruins — dramatic hilltop ruins on the central east coast. Six enclosed areas of old Ryukyu stonework with panoramic Pacific Ocean views. 1 hr.	Drive ~40 min northeast of Naha	¥400 (~\$3)
11:00	Cape Manzamo — sea-eroded elephant trunk-shaped cliff arch on the west coast. Stunning views, 30–45 min walk.	Drive ~30 min north	FREE

Midday — American Village

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
12:30	American Village (Chatan-cho) — colorful Ferris wheel, American diner food, surf shops, entertainment. A genuinely weird mix of American 50s nostalgia and Japan. Worth 1–2 hrs for lunch and people-watching.	Drive 10 min north from Cape area	FREE to explore
13:00	Lunch: American-style burger, Okinawan taco rice (a local fusion dish: seasoned ground beef + cheese + salsa on rice), or Okinawan plate lunch	Walk	~\$10–15

Afternoon — Return South

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
15:00	Okinawa Prefectural Museum (optional) — excellent natural and cultural history of Okinawa and the Ryukyu Kingdom	Drive to Naha	¥530 (~\$4)
16:30	Return rental car or keep for tomorrow (Yanbaru day)		

Evening

Time	Activity	Cost
18:30	Dinner: Izakaya on Kokusai-dori or Makishi area — share plates, awamori cocktails, Okinawan food. Try mimiga (pig ear) and umi budou (sea grapes) if adventurous.	~\$20–30

DAY 24 — KERAMA ISLANDS (Day Trip)

 **Stay:** Naha |  **Theme:** World-class snorkeling — the best water you'll see in Japan

 *Book Kerama ferry IN ADVANCE. High demand, limited capacity. Target Zamami Island (best snorkeling) or Tokashiki Island (easier to reach, bigger).*

Travel to Kerama

Time	Activity	Route	Cost
8:30	Depart hotel for ferry terminal	Taxi or Yui Rail + walk to Tomari Port (~20 min)	
9:00	Ferry: Naha (Tomari Port) → Zamami Island	High-speed ferry (~50 min) OR slow ferry (~2h)	¥3,140 (~\$21) RT high-speed
9:50	Arrive Zamami		

On Kerama (Full Day)

Time	Activity	Cost
10:00	Furuzamami Beach — 5-min walk from port. Designated marine park. Coral reef starts just 20–30m from shore. Snorkeling gear rental available at beach (~¥1,000).	FREE; gear rental ¥1,000 (~\$7)
10:15	Snorkeling — sea turtles are frequently spotted here. Coral is pristine. Water visibility 25–30m in good conditions. This is why you came to Okinawa.	Gear rental
12:30	Lunch on the island — simple restaurant near the beach. Set meals ~¥1,200–1,500.	~\$8–10
13:30	More snorkeling or beach time	
15:00	Village walk — Zamami village is tiny and quiet. Walk the hilltop for views. Look for Kerama deer.	FREE

Return

Time	Route	Cost
16:00	Return ferry: Zamami → Naha (Tomari Port)	~50 min
17:00	Arrive Naha. Shower, rest.	
19:00	Dinner: Light — you've been in the sun all day. Okinawan soba and shikuwasa (citrus) dessert	~\$10–15

DAY 25 — YANBARU NATIONAL PARK (North Okinawa)

 **Stay:** Naha |  **Theme:** Subtropical jungle, dramatic coastline, the wild end of Okinawa

Full rental car day. Drive north ~1.5 hours from Naha. The route itself is beautiful.

Drive North

Time	Activity	Route	Cost
7:30	Pick up rental car		
7:45	Depart Naha heading north on Route 58	Drive ~1.5h north	

Yanbaru National Park

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
9:30	Hiji Falls (Hiji Otaki) — Okinawa's largest waterfall, reached via a 40-min jungle trail each way. Freshwater swimming hole at the base. Lush subtropical forest.	Drive to Higashi village, park at trailhead	¥500 (\$3) entry
11:30	Drive toward Cape Hedo	Continue north ~40 min	
12:00	Lunch: Simple local restaurant in Kunigami village or bring food from a convenience store		~\$8–12 or packed
13:00	Cape Hedo (Hedo Misaki) — the northernmost point of Okinawa. Rugged cliffs, strong ocean wind, the Philippine Sea and East China Sea meeting below you. Very dramatic. 30–45 min.	Drive to northernmost tip	FREE

Drive South — Scenic Route

Time	Activity	Route	Cost
14:00	Drive south on the scenic east coast route (Route 70/331) — mangroves, small fishing villages, ocean inlets		
15:30	Kouri Island and Kouri Bridge — a stunning 2km bridge to a small island. Kouri Beach has clear water. 30–45 min stop.	Short detour	FREE
17:00	Return to Naha (~1h drive south)		
18:30	Return rental car		

Final Okinawa Evening

Time	Activity	Cost
19:30	Farewell Okinawa dinner — a proper sit-down Ryukyu cuisine restaurant. Order beni-imo tarts (purple sweet potato pastry) as dessert — the Okinawa souvenir food.	~\$20–35
After dinner	Buy Okinawa souvenirs on Kokusai-dori if you haven't yet	Budget as needed

DAY 26 — FLY NAHA → TOKYO (Final Buffer Begins)

 **Move:** Naha, Okinawa → Tokyo |  **Hotel:** Tokyo Final (Shinjuku or Shibuya, 3 nights)

Morning

Time	Activity	Route	Cost
8:00	Check out of Okinawa hotel		
8:30	Naha Airport (OKA) → Tokyo Haneda (HND)	ANA, JAL, Peach, or Jetstar Japan (~2.5h)	~\$60–120 booked separately
11:00	Arrive Haneda (HND)		
11:30	HND → Hotel in Tokyo	Tokyo Monorail to Hamamatsucho, then JR Yamanote (JR Pass )	FREE with JR Pass
12:30	Check in to final Tokyo hotel		

Afternoon — Decompress

- **Rest.** You've done a lot. Okinawa sun + travel = tired.
- Light neighborhood exploration on foot.

- **Shinjuku Gyoen** (if cherry blossoms are still showing at this point ~April 19–21) — ¥500. A peaceful closing walk.
- Or: a neighborhood izakaya lunch and walk.

Evening

Time	Activity	Cost
18:00	Don't overplan tonight. Easy dinner near hotel.	~\$12–20



DAY 27 — TOKYO: DisneySea (OR Missed Spots)



Stay: Tokyo Final | 🎯 **Two options — choose based on energy**

OPTION A — Tokyo DisneySea ⚠️ Pre-booked ticket required

Time	Activity	Route	Cost
8:00	Depart early		
8:30	JR to Maihama Station (Keiyo Line from Tokyo Station, 15 min, JR Pass ✅) then Disney Resort Line (¥260) to Tokyo DisneySea		¥260
9:00	Gates open — arrive at opening		Ticket ¥7,900– 10,900

DisneySea Strategy: | Priority | What to Do | |---|---| | First 30 min |
Journey to the Center of the Earth (Mysterious Island) — the best
ride in the park; no Express needed at opening | | Morning | **Soaring:**
Fantastic Flight — stunning flying theater, book Lightning Lane;
Indiana Jones Adventure | | Midday | **Fantasy Springs** (2024 new
area) — Frozen Ever After, Peter Pan's Neverland, Rapunzel's area | |
Afternoon | **Sindbad's Storybook Voyage** — underrated classic; **Tower**
of Terror — genuinely scary version | | Evening | **Spectacular water**
show (check schedule) + fireworks |

DisneySea is widely considered the best theme park in the world.
It's architecturally stunning — Mediterranean harbor, lost river delta,
mysterious island inside a volcano. Take your time and look at
everything.

OPTION B — Missed Tokyo Spots

Spot	Where	Cost
Roppongi Hills — Mori Art Museum 52F (¥2,000), night views	Tokyo Metro Hibiya Line	¥2,000
Hamarikyu Gardens — feudal garden with tidal pond, close to teamLab area	Subway	¥300
Tsukiji Outer Market — sushi breakfast	JR or Subway	Food ~\$10–20
Akihabara last haul — if you held back on Day 3	JR (JR Pass)	Budget as needed
Imperial Palace East Gardens — former Edo Castle grounds	JR to Tokyo Station	FREE

DAY 28 — TOKYO: Final Shopping + Packing + Airport

 **Stay:** Tokyo Final → Return flight (Day 29)

Keep this day light. You need to pack, return to the airport, and have a buffer. Do NOT schedule anything complex.

Morning — Final Shopping (Shinjuku)

Time	Activity	Getting There	Cost
10:00	Tax-free shopping — Japan offers 8–10% tax refund on purchases over ¥5,000. Show passport at checkout. Major electronics: Yodobashi Camera Akihabara / BIC Camera Shinjuku. Manga/figures: Animate or Mandarake if any last purchases.	JR to Shinjuku or Akihabara (JR Pass)	Budget as needed
11:00	Don Quijote (Donki) in Shinjuku — multi-floor discount store. Best for bulk Kit Kats, snacks, cosmetics, unique souvenirs at low prices.	Walk	Budget ~\$30–80 for omiyage
12:30	Last ramen — Fuunji (tsukemen) in Shinjuku is often cited as the best ramen in Tokyo. Queue in the morning. Or Ichiran for a solo booth experience.	Walk	~\$10–15

Afternoon — Pack + Airport

Time	Activity	Route	Cost
14:00	Return to hotel. Pack bags. Check all items. Weigh luggage if concerned.		
15:30	Check out and head to airport — give yourself extra time; Narita is 80 min from central Tokyo. Haneda is 30–40 min.	N'EX from Shinjuku → NRT (~80 min, JR Pass ) or Tokyo Monorail + JR to HND (~40 min, JR Pass )	FREE with JR Pass
17:00	Arrive NRT or HND. Check in, security. Japan immigration on the way out is usually fast.		
18:00	Last konbini run in the airport — onigiri, pocky, coffee. Stock up on last snacks.	Airport konbini	~\$10–20

DAY 29 — RETURN: Tokyo → Guatemala City

 **Sleep:** On the plane

Flight Home

Leg	Route	Time	Notes
NRT or HND → Hub	Tokyo → LAX, DFW, IAH, or MEX	11– 14h	Depart evening Tokyo time
Hub → GUA	US hub or MEX → GUA	~5h	
Total	Door to door	~20– 26h	You cross the date line back — arrive roughly same calendar day you left

At the Airport Before Departure

- Return pocket WiFi at airport rental counter (if you rented one)
 - Confirm JR Pass isn't needed anymore (it's done)
 - Final JPY → USD exchange if you have leftover cash; airport rate is poor but better than taking home coins
 - Duty-free purchases in the terminal
-

Trip Summary

Segment	Days	Cities
Travel to Japan	Day 0	Guatemala City → Tokyo
Tokyo (Week 1)	Days 1–8	Tokyo + Nikko day trip
Kyoto	Days 9–14	Kyoto + Nara day trip
Osaka	Days 15–17	Osaka
Hiroshima	Days 18–19	Hiroshima + Miyajima
Kanazawa	Days 20–21	Kanazawa
Okinawa	Days 22–25	Naha + Kerama Islands + Yanbaru
Tokyo (Final)	Days 26–28	Tokyo
Return to Guatemala	Day 29	Tokyo → Guatemala City
TOTAL	30 days	8 cities + 4 day trips

Intercity Transport Summary

Leg	Mode	Time	JR Pass?	Approx. Cost
GUA → Tokyo	Flight	~22–26h total	No	\$1,200–2,200
Airport → Hotel (NRT)	N'EX	80 min	YES ✓	FREE
Tokyo → Nikko	Tobu Line (Asakusa)	1h50m	NO ✗	¥2,800 (~\$19) OW
Tokyo → Kyoto	Shinkansen Hikari	2h15m	YES ✓	FREE
Kyoto → Nara	JR Nara Line	45 min	YES ✓	FREE
Kyoto → Osaka	JR Special Rapid	28 min	YES ✓	FREE
Osaka → Hiroshima	Shinkansen Hikari	50 min	YES ✓	FREE
Hiroshima → Miyajima	JR + JR Ferry	35 min total	YES ✓	FREE
Hiroshima → Kanazawa	Shinkansen + Thunderbird	~3.5h	YES ✓	FREE
Kanazawa → Naha	Flight (via Komatsu)	~2h + transit	No	~\$60–120
Naha → Kerama	Ferry	50 min	No	¥3,140 (~\$21) RT

Leg	Mode	Time	JR Pass?	Approx. Cost
Naha → Tokyo (HND)	Flight	2.5h	No	~\$60–120
Tokyo → Airport (NRT)	N'EX	80 min	YES 	FREE
Tokyo → GUA	Flight	~22–26h total	No	\$1,200–2,200

See [japan_todo.md](#) for reservations checklist · [japan_budget.md](#) for full cost estimates · [japan_poi.md](#) for entry fees Last updated: 2026-05-27